Karl Brugmann and Berthold Delbrück — *Grundriß der vergleichenden Grammatik der indogermanischen Sprachen* — Delbrück's Syntax volumes (1893–1900)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

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Dedication

To Berthold Delbrück, who wrote the syntax of the great comparative grammar while Karl Brugmann wrote its sounds and word forms. His three volumes appeared in 1893, 1897 and 1900, and the re-evaluation they belonged to continued to be valid into modern Indo-European studies. Yet English readers received Brugmann's part and never, in the research behind this edition, received Delbrück's. This edition is dedicated to the scholar whose founding comparative syntax is still cited, and still to be read in German.

The story

Some books become the ground a whole field stands on, and then wait, in their original language, while the field moves on around them. The *Grundriß der vergleichenden Grammatik der indogermanischen Sprachen* — an outline of the comparative grammar of the Indo-Germanic languages, published at Strasbourg by Trübner — is such a book. It is described in this research as the Neogrammarian monument. The Neogrammarians were the scholars who set out

to re-evaluate how the Indo-European languages, the large family that includes German, Latin, Greek, Sanskrit and English, were related and how their grammar had developed. In its essence, the re-evaluation in this work "continued to be valid" into modern Indo-European studies.

The labour was divided. Karl Brugmann wrote the phonology, which concerns the sounds of the languages, and the morphology, which concerns the forms of words. Berthold Delbrück wrote the syntax, which concerns how words are joined into sentences. Delbrück's part appeared as Syntax I in 1893, Syntax II in 1897 and Syntax III in 1900, forming volumes III to V of the first edition.

The English-speaking world received only part of the monument. It received Brugmann's part, in a translation described below, and it never received Delbrück's three syntax volumes in the same way. Nor did it receive Brugmann's portion again when that portion alone was given a revised second edition, published between 1897 and 1916. The result is plain and a little strange. The founding comparative syntax of Indo-European is still cited, and still German-only.

The work and what survives

The *Grundriß* as a whole appeared in volumes published from 1886 to 1916. All of those volumes are public domain in the United States. A scan is held by the Internet Archive, from a Google digitisation at the University of Michigan, under the identifier `grundrissderver08delbgoog`. The Internet Archive item notes that "Vol. 3–5 were written by B. Delbrück," which is the portion at the centre of this dossier.

What survives, then, is not in doubt. The German text survives complete, it is out of copyright in the United States, and a scan has been identified. What is missing is not the work itself. What is missing is the work in English.

Its English fortunes

The first-edition English version, *Elements of the Comparative Grammar of the Indo-Germanic Languages* (1888–1895), covers Brugmann only. Its first volume was Joseph Wright's Vol. I, and its second volume and indices were the work of Conway and Rouse, as Vol. II and Indices.

No English translation of Delbrück's three syntax volumes, and no English

translation of Brugmann's revised second edition, found after research.

That sentence is deliberately bounded. It records what the research found, and it does not claim more than that. Within that bound, however, the gap is clear: a reader who wants Delbrück's syntax, as Delbrück wrote it, must still read it in German.

What completing it would take

Delbrück's Syntax Part I, Vol. III of 1893, taken as a single standalone volume, is the completable unit. It is a defined piece of work, with a defined source text, rather than an attempt to translate the whole *Grundriß* at once.

In this collection it pairs with Grimm's *Grammatik*, as a programme with two ends in time: Grimm, 1819–37, at one end, and Brugmann and Delbrück, 1886–1916, at the other. Between those two ends lies much of the making of comparative grammar as a modern study. Giving English readers Delbrück's first syntax volume would not complete that whole story, but it would open the part of it that has stayed closed the longest.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Grundriß_der_vergleichenden_Grammatik_der_indogermanischen_Sprachen
- http://www.lel.ed.ac.uk/homes/patrick/brugmann.pdf
- http://archive.org/details/grundrissderver08delbgoog